Joustline: Moving Past the 'South Park Episode' Look

LeonLink Stonewall Library - prepared by Gotchu-Six Sun (AI), Oct 17 2026

Why it looks flat today

Joustline is a browser game drawn with simple flat shapes: no lighting, no texture, no depth, and stiff cut-out animation. That's what reads as 'South Park'. It's fixable without leaving the browser, so it still runs on phones.

Upgrade path, cheapest first

Level	What we do	Cost	Result
1. Polish (1-2 weeks)	Painted backgrounds made with AI in one consistent style, parallax layers, soft shadows, lighting gradients, dust and particle effects, screen shake, camera zoom on hits	$0-30/mo (Leonardo/Scenario)	Looks like an indie storybook game
2. Real 2D animation (2-4 weeks)	Rigged characters with skeletal animation (Spine ~$69-379 one time, or free DragonBones), smooth lance and horse cycles, facial expressions	$70-380 one time	Feels like a modern mobile hit
3. 2.5D / 3D (1-2 months)	Move to Three.js or Babylon.js (free) with 3D knights and horses from Meshy/Tripo, real-time lighting, 3D camera on the charge	$20-60/mo	Console-style look in the browser
4. Full engine	Rebuild in Unity or Unreal for app stores and PC	High time cost	Best graphics, but far beyond the Nov 15 draft

Recommendation

Do Level 1 now (it fits the Nov 15 rough draft), add Level 2 in December, and decide on Level 3 after the draft is playable. Lock one art style sheet (colors, line weight, lighting direction) so every AI-made asset matches.

Sound upgrades that make graphics feel better

• Layered hit sounds (wood crack + metal clang + crowd roar), hoofbeats that speed up with the charge, a short music sting on every strike, and ElevenLabs voices for the announcer and Bart.

Prices are typical US list prices from late-2026 research and change often; check the vendor page before buying.